Portal

The dotted lights in the night sky gave way to a dark cloud. Three middle aged men in a helicopter flew into it, the moon fading behind the veil. They were caught in something that wasn't on the helicopter's weather radar. In the briefing, they weren't told of any clouds, but the cloud was there, and appeared quickly from the abyss of the air. Flying over Sudan was supposed to be an easy trip with the Black Hawk helicopter. The two pilots had even christened it the "Lucky 13." To the special forces pilots called *Night Stalkers*, and the special forces soldier, called a Green Beret, it was nothing more than a "milk run"— a quick, easy, and safe trip.

All they had to do was not crash Lucky 13 on their way to an operating base. Red lights dimly lit the cockpit, as the Sargent Waters, the Green Beret, sat in the back along with all the cargo crates. Though with eyes shut, he was very much awake. With the engine screeching, the rattling of the crates, the whooshing of the rooters, it was difficult to be anything but awake. He hoped for a speedy journey, but a minute felt like being slowly dragged through sand under the noon-day sun.

Appearing on the window next to Waters was a sudden blue glow: they were streams of electricity. Looking at the cockpit windows, it was even brighter, thicker, and more frequent. Dancing lights on the windshield blocked much of the pilots' view, not that there was much to view at night. The lights snaked from the front towards the back on the outside of the helicopter. The rotters seemed to have become a glowing blue disk. The Sargent held tightly on to a handle, the darkness obscuring his paleness. He did his best to steady his voice.

"What's that? Are we in trouble?" asked the Green Beret, shouting over the sound of the engine.

"No," said Lee, an Asian pilot, shouting back "It's just St. Elmo's fire." Lee was a warrant officer, a rank few heard of, and had joined the Night Stalker unit months prior.

“Just St. Elmo’s fire?” Waters asked loudly.

“Yes,” said Captain Belwall, “the problem is not the electricity, it's what the cloud is. If it's a volcanic eruption, then we may be in a British Airways double-o nine situation and engines will shut! If it's a storm, then we will be fine.”

“Which is it?” asked Waters.

“No rain, no radar appearence.” said Captain Belwall, “Its volcanic.”

“Windows aren’t scratched,” Lee pointed out, “Volcanic ash would scratch the windows.”

“We just entered the cloud and it's dark,” Captain Belwall replied, “No way to tell.”

“Land this helicopter, then! Before the engines shut off!” said Waters.

“Reducing power,” said Lee, ignoring the soldier.

“One-eighty turn to our right and descend,” said Belwall. Seconds later he said loud but calmly, “now.”

The three felt a lightness, their stomachs feeling almost ticklish with the descent, as gravity pulled Sargent Waters rightward. The glow of St. Elmo’s fire and its activity diminished for a while. But no matter how low they went, the cloud continued. Lee, noticing the engines were holding well, and suggested simply focus on getting to the operating base. Belwall disagreed. They continued their low power descent. Yet, the lightning-like snakes that glowed became one, and it was starting to look like blue flames. Lee and Belwall mumbled to each other while the green beret insisted they land the aircraft.

“Bad idea,” said Belwall.

“We can’t glide down to the earth! We are going to die if the engines shut off.”

“We have plenty of time for auto-rotation. We can glide-”

“Look out!” said Lee.

Out of the cloud appeared a looming cliff face, and with the high speed of the helicopter, they barely managed to avoid becoming a fireball. The exiting of the cloud only left the three confused. Having done one-eighty, the cloud began dispersing in the night. It was just empty space now, with a mountain side being lit up by the bright moon and star-light. Out in the distance the pilots saw a red glow, as if there was a sea or ocean, but their attention was taken away as Lee mentioned the GPS being offline. The pilots continued to fly, dodging random cliffs and mountain sides.

“Where in the world are we?” Sargent Waters asked, “I thought we were going away from the mountains!”

“We were…” said Lee, “Did a mountain suddenly grow to ten-thousand feet?”

“We’re landing,” Belwall said, “Let’s take her in nice and slow.”

The descent took minutes, then tens of minutes. Waters looked outside in the darkness, trying to make sense out of anything. There were trees…where there should have been a desert. And mountains? Perhaps. The two pilots simply were looking to land the helicopter safely. But the soldier noticed something. He rubbed his eyes after looking at the sky. Nope, the two moons were still there, as one seemed to move slowly behind a skyscraper-like mountain top.

“There’s a clearing,” Lee pointed out.

The Lucky 13 landed safely down. While the GPS showed its error code, radio frequencies only captured static. The whine of the engine was reduced, the rotors slowed down. Waters was already armed with his rifle, grabbed a flashlight that cut through the darkness. The light revealed the tall, purple-dull grass, and nearby, a large bush that had several flowers measuring a foot in diameter.

“Why are you shining your flashlight outside? Do you want to be found?” Belwall asked.

“We aren’t in Sudan,” said Waters.

“What do you mean we aren’t in Sudan? We went inland from Suakin. Barely for a half-hour too!” Lee said.

“Look at the moons.”

“What?” the pilots said collectively.

Waters pointed at the sky, “right there.”

“Why would the sky have” said Lee turning his head up, “...two moons.”

The soldier opened the helicopter door, his rifle on the ready. Waters only encountered silence and cool air, brought by gusts of wind. There were no owls, no cicadas, no wildlife from Sudan or from anywhere…only what he could see: a handful of trees surrounding the area they landed, a handful of bushes with blooming flowers, and the tall purplish grass. The Lucky 13 pilots had their guns on hand, and with their flashlights. When the lights were shut, the faint red glow could again be seen in the distance, opposite of the mountains behind them.

“Let’s sleep in the heli. When morning rolls around, we can scout the area,” the Captain said.

“At least we landed on an oasis,” Lee said.

“I don’t know what kind of oasis has this type of vegetation,” Waters said as he began returning to the helicopter.

The three made the cabin of the helicopter as comfortable as they could, and they could only do so much. The three locked the doors, hoping their Black Hawk would act as a shell rather than a coffin. The floor was hard, friction-less, and cold. Crates and the helicopter walls became their pillows. The night was still.

As the light of day rose, the half-asleep military men began to wake. Belwall woke up first, and began to read his pocket Bible after a prayer. Sargent Waters woke up soon after, followed by Lee’s complaints of hunger.

“Open the MRE crate,” said Captain Belwall.

“But that's for the operating base,” Lee responded.

Without looking away from his Bible, the Captain continued, “take a good look around you Lee, we aren’t in Sudan. God knows how long we will be here for.”

Lee and Waters proceeded to go around the cargo, opening a crate of MRE rations and taking a favorite.

“Well, sir,” said Waters sarcastically, “what words does the good Lord have for you today?”

“*Fear not, I am with thee, be not dismayed. For I am thy God.*” Belwall replied.

“If he’s with us, we better find a way out,” the Sargent said as he left the helicopter.

“Don’t go too far,” Belwall said.

The large right door was opened slightly, allowing cold air to enter. Waters stepped outside to a clear morning sky. It was yellow and orange, with a sun appearing in the distant horizon. The colors of the trees, tall grass, and giant flower bush were a little brighter. It was all curious, until Waters looked up. His eyes became wide, his jaw dropped. His lingering observation of the sky caught hungry Lee’s attention, who promptly left the helicopter, while eating, to investigate.

“What are you so mesmerized about?” Lee said with his stuffed mouth. But his reaction was the same as the Green Beret’s, with some food escaping.

“Floating islands…” Waters said gently, staring beyond the bushes. “We can’t be on Earth, can we?”

“Time travel?”

“I really hoped it was a bad nightmare,” said the Green Beret, “but it's real. Too real.”

Belwall joined the two in staring at the sky. “Welcome to wherever we are gentlemen.”

Lee pointed at something moving in the distance, before going to the helicopter for binoculars. Returning with them, Lee looked through the binoculars seeing blacks and squares, attached to a large, maybe two large balloons.

“Looks like a balloon,” Lee said, handing the binoculars to Belwall. “Maybe that's the reason we are here?”

“What if it's something else?” Waters said, holding on to Lee’s shoulder, “What if they’re not human?”

Belwall looked at his gun. “If they’re hostile, you can protect us, Sargent.” Belwall began returning to the helicopter, gesturing for everyone to gather. “We will circle around the airship for a better look.”

“Bell,” Lee followed Belwall, “should we leave the cargo?”

“Not yet,” said Belwall, having gone around the helicopter’s nose, “We have no idea how long we will be here for.”

The three entered the helicopter. Each to his station, the engine whined, the rotors began to move from their lazy rest. The whining became louder and sharper, the rotors spined fast enough that one could almost not see them. The rotor wash—air being fanned away from the helicopter—pushed the purple grass down to the ground, as the bushes and tree leaves swayed away from the helicopter, waving goodbye.

“All systems check,” Lee said.

“So,” said Waters as the Black Hawk lifted off the ground, much like an elevator, “after looking at the balloon, what are we doing?”

“We head to the direction it came from,” said Lee.

A closer look at the patched balloon revealed its lack of pattern. It was simply blankets stitched together, with a tether that snapped from the basket, which seemed to hold something. The aircraft seemed to be three times the size of the helicopter, with an open bottom, like a hot balloon. Aside from the gray, brown, green-flowered, and yellow squares that made the patchy balloon there was nothing else to look at.

“You know,” said Lee, “the stuff on the basket looks like electronic equipment.”

“If it's human made, how can they make electronics in a place like this?” Belwall asked.

Belwall and Lee coordinated the turn, the helicopter becoming parallel to the mountains, heading south. Waters looked at the right of the Lucky 13, using the binoculars to look at the direction

that the glow came from the night prior. There was a haze, and he couldn't tell what he saw except for a large flareup of light, while smoke vailed the distance.

To the left side were the infinite mountains that made everything before it minuscule. The wall of rock was of a light sand color, with occasional green and light purple. Below was mixed vegetation of grasslands and forests, with hardly any hills which ran parallel to the mountains.

"I think I see something on our left," said Waters, shouting, "It's a group of dots. It looks like a small city."

The helicopter tilted slightly leftward and began a shallow turn with its descent. As the Lucky 13 got closer, the bank became steeper, revealing a dense forest of buildings made of wood, concrete, and metal. Large towers inside an oval shaped wall stood proud: one round and made of stone, and a metal-strut tower that resembled a communications array.

"Looks human," said Lee.

"Now for first contact," said Belwall. "Let's go towards the red glow and then we'll circle around to the mountain side and land there. I don't want them finding Lucky Thirteen. Let's keep her low."

"Copy," Lee replied.

After having landed among the small trees with red-hue leaves, the three armed themselves, slowly making their way eastward, at least according to their compass. They marked trees with cuts along the way. After an hour of hiking on almost flat terrain, the trio reached the tree line, and looking from it were the grass fields, with the farms they saw from above, and the

hodgepodge of buildings silhouetted against the grassy plain which were all inside the large wooden wall.

The three men stayed within the tree line, sat down or knelt, and took turns looking through binoculars at the city.

Lee looked at Belwall. “What’s the plan?”

“I’m thinking we walk up and find who they are. Or what they are. Got any ideas, Waters?” said the Captain while looking at the group of buildings in front of him.

“They look human,” said Waters through his binoculars. “Let's just go up and talk with them.”

Belwall looked at Lee who simply nodded. The three walked out, with Waters leading the way towards a dark green field of bushes. The bushes revealed tiny blue and purple fruit. Lee plucked one in passing, sniffed it and ate it.

“Blueberries,” Lee said, taking a handful, “These are blue berries.”

“You ate one?” Waters said, looking at Lee.

Lee with a full mouth responded, “yes.”

“We don’t know how these people will respond to that if they see you doing it,” Waters said with frustration.

“I won’t do it again,” Lee said casually.

Walking ever closer to the city through the large field, Waters held one of his hands high, calling a nearby woman who was gathering the berries. She was a dark-eyed pale woman with black hair

and very rosy cheeks. She slowly got up, looking at the three men with curiosity, and with a smile, waved back.

“Hi,” said Waters, waving, “can–can you speak English?”

The young woman with a smile, waved black, and with a heavy accent replied in English, “Yes, I speak some English. You are new, yes?”

“Yes we are. Listen, were are with the United States mi—”

The young woman interrupted the Sargent: “I know. I noticed by way you talk Mr, uh,” the woman then looked at the Sargent for a name, “Waters. Mr. Waters.”

“And you are?”

“Krysia,” she said with a smile. She then pointed at the city behind her. “Because you’re all new, we have to bring you in to, uh, talk with our leader. Come with me.”

The three were led by Krysia who’s smile had gone by the time they reached the city’s gate. Behind her was a group of men, women, and children who had been working on the fields. The small gates welcomed the three men in. The mismatch jigsaw puzzle of raw monotone-colored buildings was less welcoming, with brown dirt streets.

“Krysia,” said Belwall, “do you know where we are?”

“No, uh, Mr Belwall. No one knows this place. Like everyone, one day I was walking and now I’m here.”

As Krysia continued to guide the group through the tight maze of the small city, people said, in their own accent or language the word *Americans*.

“So, Krysia, is everyone from different parts of the world?” asked Belwall, “you sound Polish. And I’m hearing other languages here.”

“Yes. We all have come here on accident. The last people to come here were some girls from England. But you came from America, yes? You where the men in the flying machine. What’s it called in English again?”

“A helicopter,” said Lee.

“Yes, you were in the helicopter. You’re soldiers, so you may hear people talk. We are not soldiers. Only normal people.” Krysia said.

“We aren’t soldiers,” said Lee to Belwall.

“Not worth correcting right now,” Belwall replied.

“I am,” Waters joined in.

“You know what I mean,” Krysia said.

As the four approached the stone tower, specifically towards the outdoor rusty ladder, a large white brown-haired man placed himself in the way. He held a rifle of his own, and his palm was open as if it were a stop sign.

“Afraid you chaps can’t go beyond this point,” said the man with an English accent.

“Do you even know how to use that thing?” Sargent Waters asked sarcastically.

“Do you wish to find out?” the Englishman asked with one of his fingers on the trigger, his gun still pointed towards the ground.

“I bet my draw is quicker,” the Green Beret replied.

Captain Belwall took some steps forward, placing himself between the soldier and the guard. “I’m sure we can have a peaceable solution that allows us to keep our weapons.”

“There isn’t,” the Englishman replied.

“We’ll be leaving then,” said the Captain.

“You’ll still need to leave your weapons,” said the Englishman. “I’m sure you’ll be understanding seeing we outnumber you.”

The three looked around. Three more women and four men, all armed with something: pistol, shotgun, or rifle, surrounded the trio. Waters noticed that some of their firearms were rusty, and pulled the Captain aside.

“Sir, there’s rust on their guns. They’re bluffing,” said Waters.

“You want us all to bet our lives on that?”

“Yes,” he said with a low voice.

“We don’t need anyone else dying,” said a female voice coming from the rusty stairs. She had a perfect American accent.

All heads turned to reveal a woman dressed in an old pink skirt and dark green shirt. Her hand glided down the rails as she took each step gracefully and delicately down. She wore a deep-red

lipstick, along with shadow and eyeliner. Waters stared the woman down, unblinking, with eyes narrowed.

“I don’t like her,” Waters said to Belwall.

“Perhaps they can help us during their stay. Plus, we do not want to fight a Green Beret,” said the woman smiling at Waters. “And Night Stalkers...I wonder what you all were doing together. Where are the others?”

“Very far,” Waters replied.

“I’m sure they are. I’m Simone the first, queen of this realm.” said the woman, stopping several ladder steps from the ground. She then turned to the guard, “Mr. Avery, take these men to my hall, they must be hungry.”

“Yes, your majesty.”

The three sat at a long wooden plank table, on rough-looking wooden chairs. Three wooden bowls with a mustard-colored soup were placed in front of each of the men. At the other end of the long table was Simone, on a heavily-used black office chair. She stared at the men with interest as a servant placed soup before her.

“How did you fine gentlemen end up here?” asked Simone, leaning with one elbow on the arm rest.

“By the grace of God,” said Belwall.

“Actually, a lot of luck,” Waters added.

“Are you’re superstitious, captain?” Simone asked.

“Religious, ma’am.” the Captain replied before drinking some of the soup.

“Is there a difference?”

“A world of difference.” Belwall then ate some more.

“There isn’t much of a difference,” Waters added.

Simone smiled, “is that so?”

Lee interrupted, “how did everyone end up here?”

“Different stories depending on who you ask, warrant officer.” Simone turned to the Englishman that held the group up. “Mr. Avery, how did you end here?”

“Was walking in the middle of night, ma’am,” said the Englishman. “I was patrolling the streets in London. There was thick fog, and fourteen other people came with me.”

“No matter where they were or what they were doing, a fog comes and brings a person outside of a building,” Simone said. “It also brings strange, zombie-like people. People with metal electrical spheres as their heads that will run and kill you. So if you choose to be outside, be weary of them.”

“So rotting corpses are a thing?” Lee asked.

“No,” said Simone. “Take a regular person and place a metal dome with a computer. That is what these people are. They make no sound other than the steps they take to walk or run. They’re

abnormally strong, disregard or feel no pain, and we have no idea who makes them and why. But whoever does, they certainly control them."

"Ever killed one?" asked Waters.

"Some," said Simone. "We come across them at night when they try to attack us. Sometimes there are strays during the day. We've never been able to reverse the effects on someone either. The couple of times we tried, the person died—but it was a person. But with a Green Beret here, we may very well find who is behind this filth. What do you say, Sargent Waters?"

"I suppose it's reasonable. Perhaps even find a way back home."

"Captain Belwall. Warrant Officer Lee. I know you're only pilots. But I'm sure special forces pilots can handle something like this."

"I—I don't know—We'll need to discuss this," Belwall said.

"I understand. But remember, you only shelter here when you work for me. Otherwise, you're on your own."

The three walked on the field, toward the trees they came from. A breeze gently flew parallel to the mountains they faced. A black woman with an African accent, ran screaming to the three, pointing at something and saying in her broken English "danger! Danger!" In the direction she pointed, in the field was a person walking towards them, with a large round head. The head looked gray despite their bare arms being white. It was walking towards them at a fast speed. Then it began to pick up pace. Waters raised his gun, pointed at the creature's center mass. One shot. Two shots. Three shots. The thing fell running. The three kept their guns trained on the

creature as the soldier moved forward, turning it around. On the sphere, a red light was slowly blinking, its brightness gradually decreasing, taking it longer to light up and diminish. There were also some antennas, a couple of wires, a random tiny pipe. But the real engineering was covered by the metal plating, held together by rivets, welds, nuts, bolts, and screws. Groups of people came to gather around the men, celebrating the defeat of the creature.

“So as soon as we hear about these things, we’re attacked,” Lee said. He looked at Belwall, “Do you think it was conscious?”

“I hope not,” Belwall replied softly.

The three continued back to the Lucky 13, making sure to avoid B-lining to it, but going in a roundabout way, only directly going to their helicopter once entering the treeline.

“This place might not be a bad place to live,” Waters said.

“We just came across that…thing. You’re already thinking of staying?” Lee asked.

“How’s that different from combat? They don’t have ranged weapons. It's likely easier.”

“I have a family, and I like modern conveniences,” Belwall said, “and I do not like whatever those things are.”

Lee joined in, “I still want a family.”

“We should probably stay the night,” said Waters.

Belwall stopped and turned around, “Waters, I don’t know what changed your mind, but she doesn’t sit right with me.”

“The Captain is right, Waters. She knows you’re a Green Beret, and she knows we’re Night Stalkers. She knows I’m a Warrant Officer. What average civilian knows what a Warrant Officer is?”

“She didn’t say anything about night stalkers—” Waters was interrupted.

“She did,” Lee said, “and I quote ‘And Night Stalkers...I wonder what you all were doing together.’”

“They might know something we don’t. We have to trust the locals,” said Waters, “We will probably have to return back anyway. What are we going to do in a helicopter?”

The Captain sighed, “we can’t stay in the helicopter forever. You’re right. I’m just suspicious of becoming knights to Simone the first over there. You go back tomorrow, let us know what you learn.”

Waters nodded, “I think that’s fine.”

Belwall then added, “For the love of all that’s good, don’t tell them where the helicopter is. You might trust them. Lee and I don’t.”

“Hey, I’m trained in this kind of stuff.” Waters said, “And how else are we supposed to return home if we don’t gather all the information we can?”

Belwall and Lee didn’t answer, and the three followed the markings they left behind. Halfway to the helicopter, Lee spotted something metallic and called it out. Upon closer inspection, the three realized it was part of a vent.

“A bunker?” asked Waters.

“I doubt the entrance is nearby,” said Lee. “there is another one over there.”

Lee was pointing towards another metallic thing sticking out of the ground. However, the sun was beginning to set, and Belwall wanted to return to the helicopter as fast as possible. The trio reached the Black Hawk as the sun slowly went to sleep behind the mountains, and the two moons woke up, along with the stars. Belwall and Lee couldn't recognize any constellations. Waters didn’t try. They opened the crate full of MRE packs, and had their dinner on the grass or on the edge of the Lucky 13’s cargo door.

“We have quite a few of these here,” said Waters. “I'll have several, and use some for trade. This is better than whatever we ate earlier.”

“Fair enough,” said Lee, while taking a mouthful of spaghetti.

Waters found a clear patch and sat down. He stared at the grass in front of him, forgetting about the food he was going to eat. The MRE pack was opened, but the food inside remained untouched.

“Waters?”

“Huh?” Waters said, looking at Belwall standing in front of him.

“Are you ok?”

“Yeah. Yeah, I’m fine,” Waters said as he opened one of the smaller MRE pack.

“You don’t look fine.”

“I’m fine,” Waters insisted as he began to eat his beans and bacon.

“I hope so. We can’t give up hope on day two,” Belwall said as he extended a hand-held radio. “I tested them. We are on channel K-five. It has fresh batteries, and I’ll get you some extras.”

Waters took the radio and nodded. He was again staring at nothing, slowly chewing his food and then slowly swallowed it. Without changing his robot-like expression, Waters waited for Belwall to come back. But Waters didn’t notice that Belwall was standing in front of him seconds later, with a handful of batteries on his extended hand.

“They’re rechargeable. Bring them back. I got a charger in the Lucky Thirteen for them,” Belwall said.

It took a couple of seconds until Waters snapped out and grabbed the batteries, placing them in one of his pockets.

“What’s wrong, Waters?” Belwall asked.

“What?”

“You look like a frozen fish staring at grass,” Lee replied.

“I—I’m thinking of home,” Waters replied.

“I get it,” said Belwall.

Lee was smiling, and while pointing the MRE spoon towards Belwall and Waters said, “You know, no one will ever believe this happened to us.” Lee then went back to eating his pasta, “no one!”

“We’ll get back to our families,” Belwall said to Waters.

With more intention, Waters looked at Belwall as the Captain was about to walk away, “what if I don’t want to leave?”

“We’ve been here one day,” Belwall said.

“Better than home.”

“You don’t have a family?”

“It's breaking apart,” Waters said before taking another bite of food. “Here I don’t have to deal with all of that. Things are simpler here.”

“Where there are humans, there is always complexity. We just haven’t noticed it yet,” Belwall said.

“You took an oath to defend your country,” Lee added. “You ought to fulfill it.”

Waters turned to Lee, “what has my country done for me? I get sent to backwater villages and tearing countries for the good of freedom of my nation, only for it to back stab me.”

“Waters, what’s going on?” Belwall asked.

“I told you, my family is breaking apart. It's held by string that’s about to be cut by my wife! I don’t want to go back. I won’t even be able to see my kids!”

“Gentlemen,” said Belwall, “we’re under a lot of stress. Let’s go to sleep, we’ll wake up tomorrow, eat, and then we’ll find a way back home. Alright?” Belwall then patted the soldier’s shoulder..

Waters then called out to Belwall “I’ll—” Waters held back tears, “I’ll think about it, I’ll help you and Lee get home, but if I choose not to go, don’t try to change my mind?”

Belwall nodded. “I won’t force you to come. I’ll honor your decision to stay. But sleep on it, will you?”

Waters nodded. “I’ll sleep on it.”

He then kept on staring, this time towards the sky, which by now had clouds in the distance where the city was at. Under them was the ever present red glow, its light flickering against the clouds like flame in a candle.

The following day came, and at the place where Lee found the ventilation shaft, the trio prepared to split up. Lee and Waters did their last radio check. The pilots wished Waters good luck, reminded the Green Beret that they’re counting on any information he could get, and to maintain regular contact. Waters then walked his own way.

Lee was smiling, “I have pretty good eyesight for an Asian, don’t I?”

Belwall let out a small laugh with his smile as he gently shook his head. “Where do you think this will lead us, Lee?”

“I think it will lead us to a building not far off,” Lee said.

The two walked towards the next shaft, and then the next, and then the next, which led them to a small grassy incline in the middle of a grassy clearing. The tiny hill was no more than eight feet tall, and covered in shrubs.

“That must be the entrance.” Lee said.

“You’re probably right,” said Belwall, breaking from the treeline, towards the mound.

Lee followed. Sure enough an entrance was on the other side. It was an upright rectangular metal vault door that looked like it could withstand anything that could be thrown at it. There was some rust, especially on the rotating handle. The Captain and Warrant Officer looked at each other, nodded, and collectively rotated the handles, putting all their strength at once. The door unlocked easily.

“Too easy,” Lee said.

Before them were stairs, and the stairs led down to darkness. They both held their flashlights on their non-dominant hand while also holding the front of their guns.

“This would be a great time for flashlight attachments on the guns” Lee said.

“I’ll be sure to suggest it,” replied Belwall, “just in case we get stuck on another planet and have to go down a bunker.”

The beams of light revealed the bottom of the stairs, and the two pilots slowly went down. Inside was dry and chilly. Tiny cracks appeared on the walls, some parts chipped away, along with plaster and concrete repairs.

The two were greeted by a plain concrete room, much like a lobby, but with totes and wooden crates neatly piled. A hallway led in two different directions. The ceiling lights seemed rather modern and undamaged. The hallways in front of them had different colored lines. To the left were yellow, green, and white. To the right were red and blue. Each color was labeled.

“White is labs,” said Lee.

“We should take the blue one to the HQ.”

“Should we leave the bunker door open by the way?”

“Yes. I would rather have a quick escape.” said Belwall, leading the way to headquarters. “You got our back?”

“Got it,” Lee said, turning around, pointing his gun while walking backwards.

The two walked slowly and steadily, trying to listen for every sound that wasn’t their own. The red line continued onward towards the hospital. The Blue line diverged to a hallway on their right. Everything was untouched. Some doors to offices were open. Some closed. Many doors were simple wooden doors, with glass windows, broken or unbroken. Some had names while others only wrote the room’s purpose: DOCUMENTS, OFFICE SUPPLY STORAGE, COMMUNICATIONS, CONFERENCE ROOM, SECURITY. Regardless of the stated purpose, all rooms had some combination of paper spread across the floor, piles of boxes, unplugged computers, extra parts, and tools.

“Let’s check documents,” Belwall said.

The two slowly opened the unlocked door to the documents room. Two spots of light revealed neat cabinets, some opened with paper having fallen on the floor. Nearby were a couple of computer server units.

“Lee, how old do you think those computers are?”

“Not old.” Lee said. He then kept on looking at the room. “Hey, Bell. I found book logs on the shelf. Seems they’ve been here since the late fifties up until five years ago.”

The old dusty books were still in good condition, spanning from 1958 to 2021. Top Secret was marked on all of the historical logs. Lee grabbed the first log and began to read it as Belwall looked at the direction of the door, just in case.

“Name of the place is Point Philadelphia…tried figuring out local and global teleportation, instead ended up here—they don’t even know where they’re at— tsk, tsk...various deaths… teleportation led to an underground cave…teleporter is the ‘m-thirty seven,’ nicknamed Little Luna,” read Lee out loud, “but they were able to go back and forward regularly. Home is possible Bell.”

“I’ll start looking for it, Little Luna files, right?” said Belwall.

The captain began pointing his flashlights at the file cabinets, looking for the letter M. He found “M-37 Little Luna” He opened the creaking cabinet, and then noticed that there were more models. M-38, M-77, X-91, X-92, and so on. Belwall pulled out documentation on the Little Luna teleporter. Hundreds of pages on the machine, along with blueprints, and a small log book were available. He was about to look at the hundreds of pages, hoping for an instruction manual, but he felt the need to look at the log book. He stared at it for seconds and then proceeded to open it, hoping to find something within the word novel. On the very first page in large red letters was written DECOMMISSIONED.

“Lee, no good. It's been out since nineteen seventy seven.”

“Give me a second. Let me check the logs,” Silently the flapping pages could be heard in the darkness. “Try model one-o-one.”

“Found it.”

Suddenly, faint lights seemed to come from the hallway. Belwall called it out, but decided to take all of the M-101 teleporter's paperwork with him. They went to the door of the room and Belwall peeked out. The glow was still faint, being slightly stronger in the main hallway. The two moved carefully with their flashlights off, their eyes adjusting quickly to the faint light they had. Looking at the main hallway they came from, with the colored lines, a stronger glow came from the direction the pilots had come from previously.

"What do you think it is?" Lee asked.

"Someone." said Belwall. "Get the log books of the latest year. We'll take them with us."

The pilots began cautiously going back the way they'd come, passing the concrete room they greeted and following the three colors of yellow, green, and white began making their way towards the glow. The glow became stronger as the green line led to barracks and the yellow led to electronics and engineering. Down the hallway was the glow coming from the windows. Looking through the windows, two stories below where they were, the pilots saw a large spherical machine. Tables, and various people walking around, a couple even with white lab coats on, as a noise showed that the machine was still powering up. A consul was dead center of the large room populated with buttons, levers, lights, and gauges. A woman stood with her back towards Belwall and Lee's location. As the woman was by a consul, a couple of men holding a young woman by her arms and shoulders entered. The young woman had scratches with slight bleeds, some bruises on her face and arms, and being held while knocked out. The men below pointed at her and then went the way they came.

"Let's leave," said Lee

“Lee, we should help her.”

Lee sighed, “we should. If they took her someplace it would probably be to the hospital.”

Lee nodded. The two then began to follow the red line, which brought them all the way down the hallway. They went from wing to wing of the relatively small hospital. Every infirmary was full of neatly organized and empty beds. No tool was out of place. No cabinet was open. There was no spill of water or blood. It was all sanitized series of smooth concrete hallways and rooms.

“She isn’t here,” Belwall said.

“Lab, Bell. She must be in the lab!” Lee said.

“Lead the way,” Belwall said.

The two switched to following the white line on the concrete walls, which led to stairs going down. The two cautiously descended empty stairs, softly placing their feet down while trying to hear anything. Directly in front of them was another long stretch of hallway, with its lights off, and the horizontal hallway forcing the duo to go right or left. A white line showed right, the same direction more light came from. Both men peaked into the hallway in opposite directions. It was clear. As they took a right, the left wall had small windows, showing the counsel the woman was operating. They didn’t stop to inspect, but noticed several men and women inside, running around, readying something.

Getting to the labs, the two went room to room, slowly peaking and seeing what was inside. One was a chemistry lab, another was a meeting room, and another was a room full of computers. Opening the room adjacent to the computers was a circular object that could be detected only by

the hallway light. Belwall turned the room's light on. On the various tables was an assembly of the electronic helmet, a couple in one table being complete or nearly complete. No words were said between the two airmen.

They moved on to the next room, with its lights on, peaked in and there saw the two men looking at the young woman laying on a cold metal table. Before they could make a plan, one of the men said, "scalpel."

"Why do we need to fit her with a sphere now?"

"Don't question, just do." was the reply.

Lee and Belwall looked at each other.

"Should we go shooting?" Lee said.

"We'll alert the entire facility," Belwall said, "we don't know how many more there are."

"Got rope?" Lee asked. "We can tie them up after."

The two pilots then entered the lab, each aiming at one man, demanding their hands reach for the stars. The two men placed their hands in the air. Lee tossed rope towards one and ordered him to tie the other well. One of the assailants caught the rope and complied. Belwall then went to tie the man that took the rope. With the assailants tied on the ground, and Belwall checking the rope, their mouths were taped, The duo saw that the young woman on the table was Krysia, groaning, eyes still shut.

"We should take her to the hospital." Lee said.

“It's too dangerous. Let's leave,” Belwall said as he placed Krysia on his left shoulder.

The three began their return through the underground maze, remembering the way they came, following the lines that guided them to the hospital upstairs. On the way back, the two got a closer look at the main room with the machines.

“Is that Simone’s head-of-security?” Lee asked, “the Englishmen?”

“It is.”

“Who’s the blonde girl operating the consul?”

“Don’t know. Let’s move.”

The two went up the stairs, with Lee making sure the way was clear. From the hospital they passed by the headquarters.As the two reached the small lobby, a man turned the corner from the hallway ahead.

“Hey! Who are you?”

The two went up the stairs as fast as possible. Shots were fired, holes pierced the corner of the hallway and lobby. Belwall climbed as fast as he could while Lee stayed at the bottom to provide covering fire. Then shooting came from the opposite end, the way they had come.

Belwall radioed Lee, “I’m on the surface. Come up!”

Lee didn’t respond, and simply left his position, running as fast as he could, out-running anything that would want to compete with him. As soon as he got to the surface, turned towards the vault door and shut it.

Belwall called Lee from the top of the little hill the stairs sat under. They turned off their radios and sat in silence amidst the brush, guns constantly pointed downward at the pursuers who had reached the surface. Stiller than statues, and more silent than stones, the pilots observed the four armed pursuers, three men and a woman, who went around the little hill, trying to look for tracks on the grassy plain. Finding nothing, the pursuers complained, one saying they would have to tell the boss.

“She might turn us into a sphere head for this,” said one of the men.

“She wouldn’t go that far,” said another man.

Minutes passed with no movement or sound. Belwall and Lee returned the way they had come, taking turns carrying Krysia on their shoulders, and finally reaching the Lucky 13.

At the helicopter, Lee took care of the Polish woman while Belwall turned on the radio systems of the Lucky 13 to reach Waters.

Waters was on the opposite side of Simone in her throne room, kneeling. She sat on a large, cushy chair, on an elevated platform. Hearing Belwall’s transmission, Waters looked at Simone. With a subtle smug smile, she gave a nod.

“About time you answered. Are you alright?” Waters asked.

“We are .well…you?”

“Good. I’m doing good. You’re breaking up a bit Captain.”

“Ok. We...call… at night.”

“Copy,” Waters replied.

Waters returned his attention to Simone.

“As I was saying, Waters, you will be my servant. And as long as you serve me, you live in my city. Understood?”

Simone got up and walked towards Waters. “By my power, I hereby declare you to be my guardian, my warrior, my servant of violence. And with this slap, you will never be subject to anyone’s blows.”

Simone then slapped Waters across the face, referencing the early knighting in medieval Europe, where a blow to the back was the ceremony, which later became the sword-tap on the shoulders. The slap left a distinctive red mark. She then returned to her throne, crossed her legs as she leaned on the opposite side against her arm.

“Now I shall give you your first assignment. Take the men and women of my guard and train them with your special forces training. With their help you will find the enemy and destroy them.”

“Yes Simone,” Waters said, while kneeling.

Simone shook her head. “You can no longer simply call me Simone. Remember?”

“Yes, your majesty.”

“Now, the people who are attacking my people may have insurgents and spies here. They are trying to rile people to rebel against me. Against their Queen. If you are able to find the spies, the people wanting to ‘go home’ then you will find the very people who make the monstrosities they

use to terrorize us. That they use to convince people this world is not worth staying in. Keep that in mind. Now go rest, and hope your friends will come around to becoming like you."

"Yes, your majesty."

Waters left the tower, now a warrior for Simone I. He headed to his new home within the town and again noticed the hellish red on the clouds. Having gone to the place he was told to go, he entered a shed of sheet metal on a concrete floor. There was a bed, a small stool and table. It was a content life he had started. He then remembered he was supposed to contact the pilots. The message was just to meet up at noon the following day. The soldier then went to sleep in his sad old stained mattress.

Though he tried to sleep, only thoughts of his old life came to mind. "Of course I'm not married here…" he told himself, "but I won't be married on Earth either. And she won't get anything if I can't see our kids again." Waters shed a tear, and went to sleep.

The following day he was found right outside the entrance of the city, making ten guards do push ups on the warm ground. Waters was leading the exercise, repeatedly counting from one to three. His radio finally picked up traffic from the pilots. Telling everyone to take a break in the shade, he grabbed his radio and responded.

"We're here," Lee said.

The Green Beret dismissed everyone, grabbed his gear and headed to where they had come from days prior. As he got closer, he saw not just the two, but also the polish girl with all her bruises and injuries. Lee was right beside her with one of his arms around her. Belwall was reading a large book and some files.

“What happened to her?” he asked while casually pointing at Krysia.

“She told us she was tortured during interrogation,” Lee said.

Krysia was silent but nodded. She then began crying again, hiding her face against Lee’s shoulder. Lee returned with a sympathetic hug, and gently patted her back. Waters leaned against a tree.

“We followed the vents to the bunker’s entrance. It was bigger than what any of us thought. It's well maintained and used. We found her unconscious, in a lab. Two men were about to do some surgery on her. They were about to turn her into one of those sphere heads. That’s what they call them.”

“That’s where the enemy is. That’s great. I’ll tell Simone right away.”

“Waters,” said Lee, “Simone is behind everything. Her and a small group of people want to keep everyone here.”

“That’s not true! Why would she want to do that?”

“We don’t know,” Belwall said, “but—”

Krysia interrupted, still crying. “She’s the one controlling the monsters! Everything is her. She makes people she doesn’t like or disobeys her into those things! I’ve been in that bunker many times, and found papers saying she was with CIA. We thought the balloon with the electrical equipment was used to control them but it's not. And the English-man was part of his country’s secret, uh, spy, agency. He was part of an agency.”

“He’s either MI five or MI six,” Lee said, “Their CIA equivalent.”

“The whole facility was CIA and somehow Simone took control of it along with other officers and agents,” said Belwall.

“Lies!” Waters cried out, standing straight, “She’s lying! The bruises were put on her to lie to you both, and you’re falling for it!”

“Why is there an American woman with a French name, Waters?” Belwall asked, “She calls herself Queen and has procedures, and wants to stay in a place that has those monsters!” Belwall paused and lowered his voice, while still maintaining a firmness, “Her real name is Harla Emmeline Nordby. She stayed despite evacuation notices because of reactor problems in the facility.”

“Maybe she had to stay in order to keep it from blowing up.”

Belwall’s voice became firmer and louder. He held a file in his hand, holding it high, shaking it slightly, “What does an Industrial Psychologist know about nuclear physics and reactors, Waters? You think she really stayed behind with a group of other CIA officers so they could heroically keep people from dying in a day's long evacuation?”

“She is the one bringing people from Earth to here,” said Krysia. “My group has been trying to find a way back.”

“Liar!”

Waters began to dash towards the city. Belwall sprinted to catch up, tackling Waters to the ground. The two men began to wrestle between themselves, their harnesses, webbing, and Waters’ gun making it difficult for any man to move and pin the other down.

“What are you doing Sargent?” Belwall said while groaning.

“Trying to do the right thing. She’s a terrorist.”

“The terrorist is the Queen you’re trying to serve!”

Lee arrived and helped pin down the Green Beret as he gave a token resistance. The pilots brought him to the tree line. Krysia hid behind some trees, looking at the soldier that began to break down crying, sitting against a tree, almost in a fetal position.

“I don’t know what to believe anymore,” said Waters, “First it's just monsters, then terrorists, and now it's Simone…”

“Waters, it's been two days since we met her. Why are you trusting her so quickly?” asked the Captain.

Waters’ face was hiding behind his hand, but tears could still be seen dripping from his chin. With his other hand he pointed to Krysia. “Why are you trusting her?”

“We rescued her, from the very people who are building the spheres, Waters,” Belwall said calmly, “You’re trading one tyrant for another, Waters.”

“If you don’t believe us,” Krysia said, “then find the entrance under the city. It's under her tower she lives in. I and many others who are working against her have seen it.”

Water’s didn’t say anything for a couple of minutes. Droplets just slowly made their way to the ground. A breeze passed through the field, making its way through the trees the four were under. Sweat dripped from everyone’s foreheads.

From there, the pilots and Krysia parted away, and Waters began walking back to the city walls. The rest of the day was spent physically training the guards of the city. He ran with them, did push ups with them, and even talked with them. But through his endurance, his strength, and his charisma was the question of trust, and why he was so eager to serve Simone.

He remembered what his soon to be ex-wife did: the shouting, the demining words, the affair with one of his fellow Green Berets, the call of child protective services for things he never did, and now a divorce. Many times his wife smiled and said how "good of a boy he was." Before his last deployment she smiled while showing a picture of his little seven-year-old Billy, and three-year-old Sofia, and bragging how he would never see them again. Every time he remembered that, he closed his fist, bit his lips down hard, and blocked the flow of tears that only a father could make. No matter how many chairs she threw at him, or the threats of punching him, the police never took her away, but always said "don't put your hand on her, or we'll have to take you in." Now he had to pay her, for the right to never interact with his kids.

As the sun began to set, Waters went to report to Simone. She wore a red shirt dress and pink lipstick, as she sat on the table of her little round hall, legs crossed. Waters tried to report the quick training and leave, but Simone constantly asked if there was anything else to report.

"My fellow pilots came to see how I was doing," the Green Beret said.

"Is that all?"

"Yes, your majesty. Tomorrow, we'll be going over firearms with the guards. Though it's my understanding we don't have many."

“I believe we do. We’ve been lucky with what the cloud has brought us, including firearms and ammunition. Mr. Avery will give you them tomorrow.”

“Thank you, your majesty.”

Waters left Simone’s presence and opened the door to the stairwell outside the tower. He closed the door as Belwall’s words then rang in a loud and deep voice, like a constant bashing of a gong in a canyon that echoes for miles and miles; *You’re trading one tyrant for another…one tyrant for another…*Waters caught himself unconsciously placing his hand on the cheek that Simone had slapped, almost feeling the sting, the pain, and the tinder skin.

Seeing the spiral stairs going up, Waters went to the very top of the tower. Reaching to the top, he leaned on the short wall, opposite the end of the staircase. To the south was the ever boiling red glow, and it seemed like lava from a distance. The clouds seemed to be on fire, despite the time of day. He looked at the forests to the west, between him and the giant mountains. There seemed to be no sign of the Lucky 13. A floating island slowly began to pass by in the distance. On the opposite end of the favela-like city was the metal tower, and Waters stared at it with questions.

“Enjoying the view?” Mr. Avery asked, placing himself almost between Waters and the stairs.

“I needed some fresh air.”

“Are you supposed to be here?”

“I see no problem with it.”

“I do. Simone may trust you, but I still don’t,” the man replied.

“Ya know,” said Waters as he approached the British man, “you’re doing a poor job as head-of-security if there are insurgents in this very city.”

Waters then passed the man and began climbing down the stairs, but not before hearing the question from the British man: “Aren’t Green Berets ones who start and help insurgencies?”

“On Earth, yes. But we aren't on Earth, are we?” Waters then continued down the stairs.

The following day, during the break between training, Waters went to find fireworks. If the cloud was bringing in random things, there may have been some fireworks that existed around. He traded his MREs for it, avoiding any merchant with an American accent to avoid ex-CIA employees. There were fireworks, along with some gasoline and a lighter. He took his MRE packs, and bartered individual packages and foods inside them. He took what he bartered for and placed it all in his room, and continued the firearms training with the security of the city.

After dismissing everyone for the day, the Green Beret waited in his little shack for the night to arrive. When the night did arrive with its streets alive with silence, Waters carried what he bought to a nearby wall. He was going to place the gasoline on the wooden wall, hoping the timber would absorb it and then light it up. With the brightness of the moons, Waters felt exposed. He hunched down so as to not be seen. But finding this to be suspicious, he quickly straightened his back, and marched with his gun, slowly, heading to a section of wall that was obscured by taller buildings. But as he did so, he saw a pile of wood within the city. He made his way back into the dark allies, cautiously walking as if the ground beneath him could shatter with his weight. He found the pile of wood.

He was about to empty the jerry can when he noticed how some of the houses were made of branches and log…*Fire could spread to them. Warning them without their knowledge would be ideal. But I could be recognized later by my voice…I need time to escape after a warning.* Waters looked at the fireworks he carried. *You little guys have fuses, don't you?* He smiled. He poured the gasoline into the pile, set up the fireworks to shoot upward, making sure their fuses would light minutes away. The gas burned, spreading to anything it was on and the soldier walked away into the shadows.

He slowly made his way through the street, and with the guidance of the light of the moons, casually walked around, sometimes looking back wondering when the alarm would be sound, smoke would pillar-up, or fireworks make their screeching entrance through the air. He passed through tight and spacious areas, slowly back tracking at times. He made his way back to his shack, and waited, and waited, and waited. His gear was packed and ready for him to leave with it. But nothing. *Did it die out? Did it not catch on the fireworks? Did someone die? No one's supposed to die! Gerrett, that was a stupid idea!*

Waters opened the door and looked at the direction he thought the wood pile was. The clouds in the distance distracted him. Their ever faint glow of red and orange, mirroring the distant lights he knew of. It was then that he felt ash following down. It wasn't much. Two flakes that were cold, black and grey, coming from the glowing clouds in the distance.

A sharp whine screamed through the air, then a BOOM, with smaller crackling sounds. Then a second fire work lit through the air, and rained its shower of lights. Waters grabbed his gear, and his rifle. Shouting was heard through the city. A third and fourth rocket went through the air. It was time to head to the tower.

On the ground, Waters ran against the crowd, coming across armed guards that ignored him. Except for:

“Hey, you!” someone said behind him.

Waters turned around. “What?” he said authoritatively.

“What are you doing here? Oh! Sargent, sir!” said the man, “Why are you headed to the tower?

“I’m afraid that the fire is a distraction.”

“I can go with—”

“No. There is a fire in that direction. See if you can help. I’ll link up with any guards in the tower. Go!”

“I—Yes sir!”

Finding his way to the tower, Waters grabbed the door handle of the first door on the stairwell, pushed the door; hardly a movement happened. Looking at the gaps with a flashlight, there was a piece of wood acting as a latch: a drawbar. A door opened from the floor above, and steps down the metal spiral spares were heard. Waters was hardly out of sight, and quickly made his way down hiding behind the stairwell, next to a metal pile. Seconds later, couple of armed men ran down to investigate the fire. The men split up, one to investigate the fire, and the other to secure Simone. Knowing the layout of the tower, Waters knew the floor the guards had came from had no stairwell to the floor Waters wanted to break in to.

Before leaving the metal pile, Waters used the flashlight to find something, anything, that could be used to go between the gaps. The creaking of metal never felt louder. At the pile he began to

find a thick piece of sheet metal he thought he saw through the darkness. It was more like a long metal bar. Looking behind him, and hearing no noise, he quickly pulled it out. He then made his way to the door he wanted to open.

“Please, please, please,” he whispered to himself as he adjusted the metal bar.

It fit through the gap. The bar was shoved between the door and door frame. It felt awkward, with most of the effort and weight being on the hands and wrists, but the bar locking the door finally moved out of place and made a loud thud against the wooden floor. The soldier’s heart pounded, breathing quickened despite his attempts to control it.

“Did you hear something?” said a voice above him.

“No, why?”

“I thought I did. I’ll be right back.”

Waters quickly closed the door and placed the drawbar back against it. That’s when he noticed, he left the metal bar outside, against the railing. *Not enough time. Assume worst case scenario Gerrett.* The Sargent found stairs to a floor beneath the one he was on, followed it, and found a trap door with his flashlight. Hearing muffling sounds become louder, Waters went through the trap door, shut off his flashlight and closed the trap door.

He heard the floor boards bear the weight of a human. The steps were slow and a light beamed against the thin cracks blinding him for a split second. The footsteps became louder. He didn’t dare breathe or move. He only had his rifle, pointed from his hip towards the trapdoor, finger

near the trigger. The light then became dimmer, and dimmer. The footsteps became quicker but quieter. Soon it was only silence and darkness.

The Sargent, again, dispelled darkness with his flashlight, and reaching the dirt floor beneath, followed a tunnel that led to a vault door. The Green Beret placed his ear against it and heard nothing. He turned the wheel as slowly as he could and saw the lights already turned on inside the bunker. He closed the metal door and began making his way down the shallow ramp, his firearm drawn out. The hallway had a window, but whatever there was to see it was below his line of sight. Before approaching the window he peaked into the hallway, which led to a hallways on either side. People were passing in the far ends, but no one saw him. *I just look too suspicious. I belong here, I belong here. I'm Sargent Waters, head of security training. I have to know what I'm dealing with…This is a great environment for close quarters combat. What if the enemy has tunnels? They don't know about the fire, yet…*

Lines of various colors were on the walls, each word corresponding to a color: left were red and blue, corresponding to hospital and headquarters. To the right was green, white, and yellow: barracks, labs, and power plant respectively. Waters peaked at the window, which revealed a drop. Two stories below him was a panel, various computers with monitors facing away from him, and some machine that was below him, unable for him to see properly. Waters turned right, following the green line to the barracks. He passed by a door, which had a name. He paid no mind to what it said. The door opened seconds after he passed. *I'm planning for assault training. I'm planning for assault training*. He marched with his gun flung over his right shoulder, hoping no one would care.

"Sargent Waters," said an all too familiar British voice.

Waters turned around. There was Mr. Avery, holding a clipboard, pointing it to his office, as an invitation. Waters complied, and the door was shut. The office had some books on a shelf, a painting of London, a computer tucked away in a corner, and a flower pot. A book with writings was opened in the middle of the desk. Waters kept his eyes trained on the Englishman.

“Tell me Mr. Waters, what are you doing here?”

“I’m scouting places for assault training. It's my job.”

The brit looked at his watch. “It's o-three-fourty.”

“I wanted to do night time training.”

“Underground?”

“I got carried away. Her majesty Simone has told me about the bunker.”

“Bollocks,” the Englishman said with a smile. “She told me explicitly not to tell you of it. I think you’re a decent liar, Sargent. But the cards in this situation do not favour you if you were in any real danger.”

A knock was heard at the door. Mr. Avery went to deal with it, having the Sargent lean against the wall to be out of sight from an opened door. The security told Mr. Avery about a fire on the surface along with some fireworks.

“Its a distraction. Is her majesty secure?”

“Yes sir.”

“Keep an eye on her and deal with the fire. I’ll be on the surface shortly.”

“Yes sir!”

The door then closed. The Englishmen sat on a corner of his desk, arms crossed. “This is your doing, isn’t it?”

“Just some simple training, Mr. Avery.”

“Sargent, we do not have much time,” he said, grabbing some documents, “I’m glad you came to me, but everyone is on alert. You ought to take these to your fellow pilots and read them. There is a letter that contains everything you need to know for the plan to leave this place.”

Mr. Avery opened a blueprint as Waters packed the documents in his backpack. “This is exit C-one. It's marked off as damaged, but it's operational. There is some water on the floor and the lights don’t work. It's a thirty minute walk past decommissioned barracks. Any questions before we part ways?”

“If we open the portal, where would it go?”

“This facility was used to extract and infiltrate agents into and out of Russia during the cold war. We have preset coordinates near Moscow.”

“We’ll have to revise that. Russia is at war with Ukraine a year after you were all trapped. It would look bad to have three military men from America appear near the capital, including anyone else that manages to leave. Didn’t you ask anyone about this?”

“Secrecy is our life line, Sargent. But thank you for this information. I need two days. We’ll follow the plan on the thor day.—”

“I suggest Fort Sill or Lawton Oklahoma, in the United States. Flat terrain. The army base and the city will have facilities for injured people. They’re next to each other.”

“Will do, Sargent. In the meantime, change your camping location to be closer to exit C-one. Simone suspects you are west, towards the mountains. We’ve been tracking your group but have, conveniently, been unable to follow through.”

“What have you tracked us with? Is it Krysia?”

“No, Krysia is an agent, though she doesn’t know who I am. Most don’t. It's with the sphere heads. Their electronic equipment contains small cameras, sensors, and a microphone. We can’t talk anymore, Sargent. I’ll be making an announcement. Wait in my office for five minutes, then make your way to the exit.”

Waters did as told. An intercom announcement was made, having everyone gather on floor A, near the teleporter. The Green Beret timed five minutes on his watch. Then he proceeded to leave, going right, following the green line towards the barracks. Having reached the barracks, Waters passed by an opened door, when someone called out to him. The Sargent began to run, turned a corner, then another. Shots were fired. There was no time to look back.

Waters didn’t know where, but he knew he should keep running. Finding a dark room, he entered it, found a corner and shoved his flashlight in his backpack to hide the light and proceeded to look for the facility's blue prints. Seconds passed and he knew where to go. He left the dark room. A turn here, hiding behind a wall there, eventually he found a map on the facility wall, leading to the C-1 exit, but the hallway to it was dark. So Waters ran into the darkness. He turned his flashlight on, and found a less well-maintained section of the facility. The deeper he went into

it the more water it seemed to pool on the floor. Eventually two inches of constant water coverage made loud swishing sounds that almost echoed through the facility. *Assume they hear it.* It only took one more turn of a corner before seeing a green reflective tape that said the letter and number combination he looked for.

The man was out of breath when he went to the surface, and felt a warm night air coming from the south. The red glow seemed ever closer, like an ocean or sea, wanting to consume all in its path. *This is still better than dealing with a poor-excuse for a wife.* Looking around he noticed he must have been no more than a mile away from the city, on the open plain behind a small pile of dirt, placed to cover the entrance. Waters leaned against the vault door, taking deep and slow breaths while his muscles slowly relaxed.

By day break, Waters had made it to the helicopter. Krysia was sleeping in the Black Hawk, while the pilots stayed outside, looking over the documents obtained. They exchanged all the information they knew with each other: the portal operation, the nuclear reactor, and the three entrances.

The letter revealed how the facility was taken over: a faked nuclear incident that could not be reversed, coupled with the fact that the glow in the distance was molten rock, slowly eating the crust of the planet, creeping ever closer to the city. Because the planet they were on would be destroyed, there was little interest to continue teleportation to it, leaving Simone to rule as she pleased. The clouds in the distance were often ash and smoke, reflecting the light the molten rock emitted. The planet was eating itself. The letter also contained a plan: distraction in the city, a forcible entry through the entrance the pilots discovered, while the pilots and the soldier would secretly enter C-1 to turn on the teleporter. Mr Avery would meet them at the teleporter room.

Mr. Avery revealed he originally supported Simone, but had regretted it. He signed off the letter by saying, “I’m sorry I’ve done this. If I’m lucky, I’ll pay for my sins.”

“Mr. Avery said we need to move to a new location, and to give him three days to adjust the teleporter.”

“Where to?” Belwall asked.

“Why don’t we just kill that woman? She’s a tyrant to us anyway. We have every right!” Lee said.

“Someone would take her place,” said Waters, “But remember what Avery said about the plan. It will happen in three days at midday. Let’s stick to the plan. And last night I think I saw a nice place not too far from the entrance where we can place the helicopter for the time being. It will make for a good escape, we can fly one mile to the cloud, and get home to Fort Sill.”

The pilots agreed, and everyone went to eat their lunch. Waters found a tree, sat on it and stood silent, again looking at nothing. *The consul might have to be defended…I could do it. I’d get my wish and help people at the same time…*Waters then noticed the Captain standing tall, shaking his head. Waters shook his head and looked away.

“You said you wouldn’t try to convince me, Captain.”

“It was wrong for me to promise to abandon you. What am I supposed to tell my creator when I die?”

“Tell him it was my choice. Tell him that I died helping you, and the people trapped in this God-forsaken place. He doesn’t care about me anyway. I don’t have anything left to live for,

Cap. Ok? I did everything right, and I can't see my kids anymore! I sacrificed my time, even my family for the sake of my country. I made enough for my family to live well. And she still cheats on me, then accuses me of that! I can't take it anymore! If I'm failing, let me fail on my own terms! Things are tangible here. I know what's black and white. I know my right from my left, Captain. There are no laws, no false accusations, no slaving away for someone who hates me by a government that's employing me. It's better this way, Captain."

"No, it's not better! It's not better for you to abandon your children! It's not better for you to stay in a place on a self-consuming planet and make it your grave. You owe it to your children to make it back to them. You owe them every ounce of will so they can grow up with you! You owe it to them to make home a better place."

"The chances are very low, Captain."

"You're a Green Beret. You deal with long odds all the time!" Belwall paused for a moment. The Sargent was starting to tear up. Waters was then picked up by the Captain, and given a hug.

"Waters. I need you. Lee needs you. Krysia needs you. The people in that city need you. More importantly, you children, back home need you. Don't give up on them. Do the right thing. Get your head on a swivel and let's go home together."

The Sargent hugged the Captain back, and through the tears, and his head between Belwall's shoulder and head, the Green Beret nodded. "Ok, Captain. I'll do it."

"Good man!"

The three entered the helicopter, where Lee had finished preparing everything for take off. The engines whined, the rotors sluggishly began turning. The pilots were on their seats. Krysia began to awaken. The Sargent looked away, looking through the window, noticing some flakes of ash in the air. The Lucky 13 turned towards the mountains before moving to the position north of the city, where the C-1 exit was. A small divit was large and deep enough for the Black Hawk to hide in, almost like a bowl, covered in a pale green grass, with rocks.

Days came and went, until the third day, smoke arose at noon in the city. A white plume rose fast, and fireworks shot in the distance.

“They’re copying your idea, Sargent,” said Lee.

“They better have given me credit,” Waters replied.

Lee stayed in the helicopter as Belwall, Waters, and Krysia went into the bunker, with Krysia as their unarmed guide. Belwall still held onto blueprints in case they separated. They waded through the shallow water as they heard the echo of gunshots. Eventually they found the area of the firefight, opposite of their position on the third floor from the bottom up.

“Come with me, I’ll show you how to get down,” Krysia said.

Before the Captain could follow, the Sargent stopped him. “I need you to cover me as I go down there. I’ll be exposed.”

“I’m not good with a gun Sar—”

“If they look like bad guys, just shoot at them sir. Trust me.”

Waters followed Krysia towards a hallway. The Captain shot the glass in front of him. The splash was only one among various sounds in the chaotic orchestra. It was a minute later that Captain Belwall saw the Green Beret moving from one side entrance, opposite of the gunfight, to the consul, amid the computers. And below, two of the turned humans, with the spheres on their heads began making their way around the consul room, with makeshift weapons in their hands.

The Captain took aim, and fired at one. Its corpse collapsed. The other took one look at the Captain, and as the Captain took aim, it ran away. On the first floor below, the Green Beret was crawling, closer and closer towards the consul, moving from concealing position to another. He got to buttons and levers, and began working on the dials of the panel. The pilot above shot at anyone who pointed a gun at Waters. The spherical machine began to turn on. Closer shots were heard and the Green Beret returned fire as he began to retreat towards where he had come from.

“CAPTAIN! LEFT!” Krysia said with a bloody scream, barely returning.

It was the sphere head he hadn't killed, swinging a metal pipe. The Captain dodged the swing, took two steps back, aimed the gun from his hip and fired. The sphere head was stunned for a second, despite the shots hitting his abdomen. It then rebalanced itself, and with the lead pipe overhead, it swung it down towards the Captain, who dodged and shot at the creature again. This time, it aimed for the head. It was knocked to the ground, twitching. Two more shots were inserted for good measure, and all movement ceased.

“Captain,” said Krysia, “We came across Mr. Avery, our leader. He said that he needs another man in the reactor. “Sargent Waters volunteered, and he wants us to return to the helicopter.”

Belwall gave the girl a flashlight. “You leave. Have Lee wait, unless he thinks the cloud is disappearing.”

Krysia took the light and left the way they came. The Captain began going down the stairs, reaching floor two. Quick step after quick step, he reached floor one. A man, wide eyed, began to take aim, but Belwall already was on target, and the man collapsed. The Captain continued to follow the yellow lines past rooms and offices. In adjacent hallways connected to his, shooting and shouting was all that could be heard.

The yellow line led him to a wall with mesh wire glass. On the other side was another wall with broken glass, and two men shooting across the circular room. Seeing it was towards Mr. Avery and Sargent Waters, The Captain shot through the glass and the two men slumped down. As he entered the room through the door, a bullet whined by him and a thud was heard on the door frame he stood next to, followed by cement dust. Belwall fell to the ground.

“Don’t shoot Sargent! It's Bell! It's Bell! Captain Bewall!” he shouted.

“Sorry, Captain!”

The Captain went across the circular room, where there were panels and computers. On the ground was Mr. Avery, open eyed, with a rifle in his hand. Belwall went to check the Englishman's pulse. Nothing.

“Dead,” said the Captain, “Let's go soldier. We’re out of here.”

“I can’t move my legs, captain. I’m weak,” Waters said with some dizziness. A drop of blood went down his mouth, while some on his forehead. A small pool formed near one of his legs.

The pilot quickly grabbed some gauze and packed the leg, then tied the bandages as well as well as he could.

“You go, sir. You…”

The Captain took the Sargent on his shoulder and proceeded to leave the room. He checked around. Occasional shots could be heard, but they seemed to be on other ends of the facility. The Captain tried to move as fast as he could, but to no avail.

“Hey, you!” said someone behind him.

The Captain turned around. He felt it was his end. But seeing a Hispanic man, armed, dressed in regular clothes, with a goatee, wearing a radio harness.

“Need some help, compadre?”

“Yes, I do.”

The Hispanic man began to help him, and asked about Mr. Avery. The Captain carried the Sargent by the shoulders, while the Hispanic man by the legs.

“Dead. He died in the reactor room.”

“I’ll have to call everyone to retreat then,” the man said, pausing.

With an accent, the man said something over the radio and gave the order to retreat. Then they continued to carry the Sargent away. It took about forty minutes before reaching the exit. Both men mentioned how the cloud must have dispersed by then. Reaching the door, the two opened, only to hear the helicopter start to fly. Lee landed it near the bunker exit when noticing the

Captain carrying the Sargent. The Captain and Hispanic man approached the Lucky 13 with hunched backs and lowered heads, then placed the Sargent in the Black Hawk, with Krysia helping to pull the Sargent in.

“Krysia, secure Waters. Put a blanket on top of him!” The Captain began to make his way to his seat.

The girl nodded. When the Sargent looked at the direction of the city, he noticed the purple cloud still there, strong, with people still running towards it. The Hispanic man then shot out of the helicopter.

“Those things are here!” The Hispanic man said with an accent.

The Captain went on his seat, as another sphere head creature tried making its way towards the Lucky 13, its blade hitting its metal head, scratching it and causing the thing to fall. The helicopter began to take off as a third grabbed on the floor’s edge, where the cargo door slid shut. It began to bring its other hand on, and climb. Krysia shot at it, making the thing fall. As the Black Hawk flew at a low altitude, a slight vibration could be felt.

“Lee, before we leave for home we need to check on the people on the other entrance.”

“Why?”

“Let's see if anyone’s there!”

“What about the cloud? It might disappear.”

“It doesn’t disappear immediately, remember? It floats off. It was floating away before we got here. We have time. We’ll just have to chase it,” Belwall said. “There are people who want to go home too. Let's check.”

“Copy, sir!”

The helicopter raced past the purple cloud, as scores of people from the city ran towards it while being shot at. The pilots found a clearing full of people. The people below waved at the pilots. The Hispanic man said he recognized a friend. The Black Hawk began to land gently, as about fourteen people entered. The MRE crates were pushed out, yet the helicopter was still crowded, and now, sluggish.

“We’re overweight sir,” Lee said as the Lucky 13 turned around.

“Full throttle, we’ll make it through, Lee.”

The cloud was now floating away, in the very direction they had come from days. The sound of metal hitting metal was heard on the helicopter. Someone shouted that they were being shot at. The helicopter’s first pass failed to bring anything, and the clinking of shots hitting the Black Hawk continued. On the second pass, the pilots steadied the Lucky 13. The rotors began to have glowing blue, like the first time they flew into it, but fainter. The helicopter continued to move, and coming across the other side they saw greener grass and trees. In front was a group of buildings connected by roads stretching for miles around, surrounded by fences. A short mile away were more buildings and roads. As they all circled around, a large group of people were below them, running towards the nearest building.

“WE DID IT!” someone shouted

Everyone cheered, until the Black Hawk's vibrations became more violent. A strange sound became louder and louder. The pilots moved the helicopter against whatever force it was pushing towards. It wanted to lean right, they went left. It wanted to face left, they turned right, and they slowly went down until the tail made them face right ward, and the Lucky 13 began to spin.

Dust covered everything as the vibrations became more violent. People shouted as they shifted around, tumbling on each other. Dirt and stones made noise against the metal frame of the helicopter. The engine whined as the Black Hawk was placed into a halt, and the cabin's air became brown.

"Shut it off! Shut it off!" said Belwall.

"I'm trying!"

The noise ended. The rotors came to a stop. The doors were opened. Lee and Belwall helped people to leave, one at a time. Some left out by themselves. People from all over the world, now in a country they've never been before.

Belwall saw Waters, after the helicopter was vacated, with his arms wide open and legs in awkward positions. He dragged Waters out and with Lee's help they placed him on the ground. Nearby a Humvee quickly approached. The people waved, as if it needed any attention. Belwall carried the Green Beret in his arms towards the incoming Army Humvee, while Lee flagged it down. He said his friend needed help. The Sargent was still breathing, heart pumping slowly, and eyes half opened.